

fired. (SOUND: *Loud "bang."*) The bullet struck the lion (SOUND: *Wail of injured dog.*) between the goldenrod and the setting sun. The bullet glanced (SOUND: *Long whine of traveling bullet, sometimes near, then far away, then near again.*) and struck the side of the mountain, splitting the mountain (SOUND: *Crash.*) wide open. Out rolled tons and tons and tons of pure yellow gold. Quickly Solomon and Ada gathered it all up and placed it in a gunny sack. This Solomon securely fastened on Ada's back (ACTION: *Places pack on Ada's back.*) and they wended their way south towards Cactus County (ACTION: *They exeunt.*) away from the land of ice and snow in the Yukon where short men have to wear high heels to keep their chins above the snow, and it is only the very tall men that can go barefooted in the winter-time.

Time marches on. (SOUND: *March of drum.*) Now our story shifts back to the old home in Cactus County. (ACTION: *Enter JOHN, ELIZABETH and EBENEZER.*) John and his good wife Elizabeth Elsie Evangeline Emeline Hinkleberry are sobbing (ACTION: *As before they daub eyes and wring out bandana.*) in great distress. (SOUND: *Record offstage may play "Hearts and Flowers."*) The cruel Ebenezer Scruggs is threatening (ACTION: *EBENEZER threatens them with baseball bat.*) to cast them out in the snow unless the mortgage on the old home is paid in three minutes. The door is suddenly opened and Ada and Solomon enter (ACTION: *Ada is lugging sack. Solomon is pushing baby buggy. SOUND: Baby cries.*) with their riches. It so happens that Solomon recognizes Ebenezer as an escaped convict for which there is a reward of ten thousand dollars for Ebenezer Scruggs, dead or alive, so Solomon shoots Ebenezer (ACTION: *SOLOMON shoots EBENEZER with slingshot. EBENEZER carefully lies down as if dead. All help drag EBENEZER off.*) on the spot. After removing the body (SOUND: *Phonograph offstage plays wedding march as they drag body off.*) to the smoke house they live happily ever after.

CURTAIN

TRAGEDY OF THE SEA

A Mellerdrammer

By

ARTHUR L. KASER

CHARACTERS

ROSABEL MACDOOGAL.....the daughter of an old salt
CAPTAIN JOHN MACDOOGALRosabel's father
SARAH MACDOOGAL.....Rosabel's stepmother
STEVE LUBBER.....Rosabel's sweetheart
RUFUS NORMAN.....the wealthy villian
MAMIE.....from the lighthouse
CONSCIENCE.....in person

ABOUT THE CHARACTERS

ROSABEL is a typical melodrama heroine. Clumsily girlish; gingham dress. Too much rouge. Too dramatic in delivering lines. CAPTAIN, a typical old sailor. Has beard. Always wears his cap. Overdoes his sealegs when walking. SARAH's tall and thin. Tight-fitting house dress that accentuates her thinness. Wears silver-rimmed spectacles. Hair done straight back. Sharp-tongued. STEVE is a typical melodrama hero, immaculately attired. Too much rouge and eye penciling. RUFUS, a villain of the old melodrama days. MAMIE: girl about sixteen. Very drab housedress. CONSCIENCE: girl covered with sheet from head to foot. Flits about trying to imitate a light-footed dancer. Makes funny attempt at sepulchre voice.

SCENE: *Old fashioned furnished living room. Few chairs and old pieces to dress stage. Stand at Center on which is a lighted lamp. Table upstage on which is ship model and an old styled radio. Hanging over the table is a very old rifle. Blunderbuss if available. Entrances Left and Right stage.*

AT THE RISE OF THE CURTAIN: *We discover ROSABEL, CAPTAIN, SARAH and STEVE. CAPTAIN is pacing the floor with hands behind him. SARAH is standing at one side of the stage playing with a yoyo. STEVE and ROSABEL are standing Center holding hands. Wireless code suddenly sounds loudly on the loud speaker. This code is done mostly in ragtime rhythm and is meaningless. It may be produced by a buzzer backstage. No one on the stage is speaking.*

CAPTAIN (*Stops walking and bawls loudly.*) Shut up! (*Listens to the code. Code stops.*) Humph! Weather report. Equinoctial storm on the equinoctial. (*Shakes a warning finger at the others.*) I don't want anybody in this house to go near the equinoctial this night. (*Whirls about, facing STEVE and ROSABEL.*) Now what's all this foolishness?

STEVE. Captain, I have come hither this night to seek the hand of your beautiful daughter, Rosabel.

CAPTAIN. You can't have her.

SARAH. When Rosabel marries she must marry for money.

ROSABEL. I marry only for love.

CAPTAIN. Daughter, do not argue with your stepmother.

ROSABEL. Father, Steve Lubber is a poor but honest man.

STEVE. Captain, I am a poor but honest man.

CAPTAIN. Young man, it isn't that. My daughter must marry a man of the sea. My father was an old salt. His father was an old salt. His father and all before him were old salts. The family has been pickled for centuries.

STEVE. But, sir . . .

CAPTAIN. Yes, I know. You're in the insurance business selling butter and eggs and cheese and milk . . .

STEVE. And fix radios and lawnmowers.

SARAH. When Rosabel marries she must marry for money.

ROSABEL. You said that twice.

SARAH. Maybe you'll marry twice. I did.

CAPTAIN. So did I. Her husband is luckier than me. He died.

STEVE. Sir, I have come hither this night to seek the hand of your beautiful daughter.

CAPTAIN. I heard you before. If you want to marry yonder beautiful daughter you must follow the sea. Hark ye, Steve Lubber. This night I am leaving for Africa on the good ship Susan.

STEVE (*Draws himself up and speaks dramatically.*) Captain MacDoogal, I am going with you.

ROSABEL. No, no, Steve! You cannot leave me alone!

STEVE (*Pushes her roughly away.*) The heck I can't.

SARAH. Let him go, Rosabel. Good riddance. (*She gets herself tangled in the yoyo string.*)

CAPTAIN. Then come, me lad, we're off. Only you're off more than I am. Come, the good ship Susan is off for Africa. (*Tosses some money on the stand.*) There, Sarah, is money for living expenses till we return. A dollar and eighty cents. I want the change back. Goodbye, Rosabel. Take good care of your stepmother.

SARAH (*Snaps.*) I can take care of myself.

STEVE (*To ROSABEL.*) Goodbye, my love. I shall return when I get here. Sooner, my love, if not earlier.

CAPTAIN. Follow me, you land lubber. I'll make a sailor out of you, or bust. Two bits I bust. Yes, me laddie, I'll make a sailor out of you.

ROSABEL. Oh, father, leave him here and I'll make a husband out of him.

CAPTAIN. He has much to learn, daughter. (*To Steve.*) For instance, if I yells, "All hands on deck, the ship is leaking!" what would you do?

STEVE. Put a pan under it and go back to bed.

CAPTAIN. What would do if a sudden storm came up on the starboard?

STEVE. Sir, I would throw out an anchor.

CAPTAIN. What would you do if a storm came up aft?

STEVE. Sir, I would throw out an anchor.

CAPTAIN. And if a terrific storm suddenly came up forward, what would you do?

STEVE. Sir, I would throw out an anchor.

CAPTAIN. Listen, ye land lubber, where would ye be getting all those anchors?

STEVE. The same place you're getting all those storms.

ROSABEL. Oh, Father, if poor Steve gets seasick, what'll he do?

CAPTAIN. Don't worry. He'll do it. Off to Africa in the good ship Susan. (*He exits Left followed by STEVE.*)

ROSABEL (*Looks after them.*) They're gone! (*She bawls loudly like a small child that has been severely punished.*)

SARAH (*Threatens her with uplifted chair.*) Shut up! Get out! (*She chases ROSABEL out at Right. Then returns to Center and*

looks off Left. She, too, bawls, but much louder than ROSABEL. Stage light go out momentarily. Sarah exits during the blackout. Lights come on. Stage hand crosses displaying a large sign: "Three months later." Enter SARAH with the yoyo, Right. Has difficulty operating the yoyo. Knock on the door, Left. She ignores the knock while she tries unsuccessfully to work the yoyo. Knock impatiently repeated.)

SARAH. Come in! (Enter RUFUS.) Rufus Norman, the villian!

RUFUS. Curses, you old sourpuss!

SARAH. You old flatterer. What do you want?

RUFUS. Curses! Where is Rosabel?

SARAH. Down by the beach playing hopscotch with the clams.

RUFUS. Curses, foiled again! For three months she has evaded me. For three months she has spurned my love.

SARAH. The poor simp cannot forget Steve Lubber.

RUFUS. Curses! Listen, woman, I have a proposition to make to you. I know why you married Captain MacDoogal. You thought he had money. But he fooled you. You crave money. You want money. That is all you think about. Listen, Peanut Pan, if you persuade Rosabel to marry me before the ship returns I will give you one thousand dollars.

SARAH. One thousand dollars!

RUFUS. One thousand dollars! I am rich. A thousand dollars is but a buck in the drop it—rock in the bubbet—one thousand dollars!—C. O. D.

SARAH. I'll get her to marry you if I have to give her my yoyo.

RUFUS. Ha, ha, ha! Ho, ho, ho! Haw, haw, haw! I'm so pleased I have laughed in three different languages. (Exits, Left.)

SARAH. One thousand dollars! I'll be rich! I won't say anything about it and I won't have to pay any tax. But I must hurry. The ship will return soon and that bum Steve will be back. (Enter ROSABEL, Right.)

ROSABEL. What is the date?

SARAH. It isn't time for the ship to come yet. Rosabel, you're a fool.

ROSABEL. Yes, stepmother.

SARAH. Why don't you marry Rufus Norman and be rich?

ROSABEL. I will marry no one but Steve. Why do you want me to marry that villain?

SARAH. Because it would be for your own good and I love you too much to see you marry a poor man. Look at me.

ROSABEL. Yes, you *are* a mess.

SARAH. I love you so much I will give you fifty dollars if you marry Rufus.

ROSABEL. No.

SARAH. Seventy-five dollars.

ROSABEL. No.

SARAH. One hundred dollars.

ROSABEL. No!

SARAH. Rosabel, just to show you how much I really love you, I'll give you my yoyo.

ROSABEL. Not even for the yoyo.

SARAH (Angrily.) You'll marry Rufus Norman or I'll... (Hisses in ROSABEL's ear.) I'll push you off the precipice.

ROSABEL. That's a big bluff. If I cannot marry Steve I'll let you push me off the precipice.

SARAH (Snatches up the chair and threatens to strike ROSABEL.) I'll . . . (ROSABEL screams and runs out Right.) That vixen shall not cheat me out of a thousand dollars! I'll bring her to time or . . . (CONSCIENCE has stealthily opened the door at Left and stepped inside. She now dances in front of SARAH, frightening SARAH.)

SARAH. Who—who are you?

CONSCIENCE. I? I am you conscience.

SARAH. No. I never wrapped up my conscience in a sheet. Anyway, I could wrap mine in a napkin.

CONSCIENCE (Dances around SARAH, then stops.) Everyone has a conscience, but many cover them up. Why don't you kill your husband?

SARAH. No, no!

CONSCIENCE. Why not?

SARAH. Oh, that would be awful!

CONSCIENCE. Then come with me and burn down your neighbor's house. You'll enjoy that.

SARAH. I would enjoy it? No, no! I would despise myself for doing such a sinful thing.

CONSCIENCE. How do you know it would be sinful?

SARAH. I—er—I don't know, but . . .

CONSCIENCE. I'll tell why you know: It is I . . . your conscience, that tells you when a thing is wrong.

SARAH. My conscience! Yes . . .

CONSCIENCE (Shakes a finger in SARAH's face.) Then why don't you heed me when I keep telling you that it is wrong to accept a thousand dollars for the scheme you have in mind?

SARAH. You know?

CONSCIENCE. I am your conscience.

SARAH. Oh, Conscience, help me. I've been a bad woman. Help me to be a good woman again like I used to be. I used vinegar in my coffee. I ate vinegar candy. I put vinegar on my pancakes. Oh, Conscience, I've turned sour. Please help me!

CONSCIENCE. I will help you. You have but to listen to me at all times, and do as I say.

SARAH. I will—always.

CONSCIENCE. Sweet dreams. *(She dances out the door, Left. SARAH gapes after her a moment. Then throws the yoyo offstage and starts to straighten up the room as she sings. Enter ROSABEL, Right.)*

ROSABEL *(Amazed at hearing SARAH singing.)* Stepmother!

SARAH. My dear, for a long time I have been your stepmother. Now I have gone a step-farther and will not be your stepmother, and will be your mother without a step. My dear, will you help me straighten up this room? I have a feeling that the ship will be in soon, and we want to make everything comfortable for John and dear Steve.

ROSABEL *(Aghast.)* Well, I'm a monkey's grandmother! You mean . . . ?

SARAH. I used to be mean, but now . . . *(Sings.)* Tra-la-la! She came to see me all wrapped in a sheet.

ROSABEL. She? Who?

SARAH. Oh,—er—nobody.

ROSABEL. Nobody wrapped in a sheet?

SARAH. Yes, yes, that was it. The sheet was empty. *(Knock on the door, Left.)* Come in! *(Enter RUFUS, Left.)*

ROSABEL. Excuse me. I have an errand to run.

RUFUS. Wait. I would a word with thee.

SARAH. You cheap hunk of diabolical nothing, if you've come to pester this poor girl again, you might as well save your breath to blow up tires.

RUFUS. But that thousand . . .

SARAH. Yes, I know. This makes one thousand times you've been here, but this is the last time. Now get out!

ROSABEL *(Points finger at him.)* Yes, villain, go! Let not me see your face on the door sill again. *(Sputtering code sounds on the loud speaker.)* Our call letters. Listen!

SARAH. Read it, Rosabel. I don't know how.

ROSABEL *(Speaks slowly as if following the message as it*

comes in.) "Good ship Susan due to dock tonight unless storm holds us up. Weather getting very bad." They're coming, Mother. They're coming!

RUFUS. Curses! Girl, you shall yet be mine!

SARAH. You shall yet be nuts! *(Very loud clap of thunder.)* The storm! *(Storm breaks with wailing wind and thunder.)* The Susan can't take it!

ROSABEL. Is the light in the lighthouse burning? *(Runs to the door, Left. Opens it. Storm sounds increase in volume. She closes the door.)* The light still burns in yonder lighthouse.

RUFUS. Curses! If I can't have you, girl, nobody else shall. *(He snatches the rifle from the wall and runs out Left as the women scream. A moment later a gun shot is heard. More code.)*

ROSABEL *(Slowly.)* "No light in lighthouse. . . . We've run aground. . . . Ship breaking up. . . . We" Mother, that's all! Something's happened!

SARAH. My John.

ROSABEL. My Steve! *(They hug each other. Then part and start in opposite directions. A terrific clap of thunder sends them back into each other's arms again. This is repeated two or three times. A muffled voice off Left.)*

SARAH. What was that?

MUFFLED VOICE. Open the door!

ROSABEL. Open the door! *(She runs over and opens the door at Left.)* Steve! Father! *(Enter STEVE, half carrying JOHN. Places JOHN in a chair.)*

SARAH *(Hugs JOHN.)* John! What happened?

ROSABEL *(As she and STEVE embrace.)* My Steve! What's the matter with father?

CAPTAIN. Not much, thanks to him. *(Nods toward STEVE.)* The Susan went aground and busted. I twisted me leg and couldn't swim. Steve put me on his back and swum ashore. Better hang onto him, daughter. You'll never get a better one.

SARAH. Did you see that Rufus Norman? He grabbed that rifle off the wall and ran out of here.

STEVE. So! Captain, that scoundrel shot the light out of the lighthouse.

CAPTAIN. And wrecked me ship. I'll—I'll . . . *(MAMIE bursts in the door, Left.)*

MAMIE. Rufus Norman! Rufus . . .

CAPTAIN. Yes, Mamie, what about him?

MAMIE. Father sent me here from the lighthouse to tell you. Rufus Norman shot the light out.

STEVE. Just as I thought.

MAMIE. But when he did the strong wind caught a big piece of broken glass and it sailed through the air and struck Rufus on the head and killed him.

SARAH. Glory be! Mamie, go tell your father to come over and have supper with us.

CAPTAIN (*To the audience.*) Next week we play "Uncle Tom's Cabin."

CURTAIN

A THIEF IN THE HOUSE

A Melodramatic Travesty

By
ARTHUR L. KASER

CHARACTERS

MRS. HARDNUT.....a wealthy dowager
GERALDINE LEMON.....her secretary
MARY JONES.....a poor but honest housemaid
HAROLD HARDNUT.....Mrs. Hardnut's nephew
JACK HART.....Mary's sweetheart
PINSETTI PENICILLI.....Harold's crooked pal

ABOUT THE CHARACTERS

MRS. HARDNUT—A buxom dowager. Overdressed and bejeweled. Uses lorgnette excessively. Is overbearing.

GERALDINE—Well dressed. Shifty eyes. Curl to lip. About twenty.

MARY—Eighteen years old. Honest and straightforward. Pretty, but inexpensively clothed.

HAROLD—A nicely dressed man of twenty-two. Subtle. Walks as if his feet pained him.

JACK—About twenty-one. New clothes but of an inferior quality. Clothes do not fit any too well.

PINSETTI—Swarthy complexion. First entrance, mediocre clothes. Later, policeman's coat and cap. Large belt that supports a sword, large hatchet and policeman's club. Carries shotgun and large revolver. Wears black mask over eyes.

SCENE: *Living room. Entrances at Left and Right stage. Library table up Center. Lamp and books on table. Left of table,*